

INTRODUCTION

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ORTHOGRAPHY AND PRONUNCIATION

THIS Dictionary is written in the Standard Orthography recommended by the all-Baganda Conference of March 1947 and officially accepted by the Government of Buganda and the Protectorate Government.

An important feature of the spelling is the use of double vowels and double consonants.

Double vowels are pronounced long, and single vowels short. Stress is usually on the first syllable of the word stem, whether it be short, as in **ku-sasira** (*to strew grass*), or long, as in **ku-saasira** (*to pity*). Here the language differs from Swahili, where stress and vowel length usually come on the second last syllable.

In the case of double consonants, the first has syllabic quality and is therefore represented by a slight pause. The nearest approach to these sounds in English may be found in expressions like "mad dog," or "good day," as opposed to "woody."¹

The values of the letters are as follows:

a and aa (short and long), e.g. **musala** (*bark cloth*), **balaba** (*they see*)
musaala (*wage*), **baalaba** (*they saw*).

The vowel quality is as in Swahili.

b and bb (short and long), e.g. **ku-ba** (*to be*)
ku-bba (*to steal*).

Single **b** is very soft, especially between vowels; double **b** is as in "sub-basement."

c and cc (short and long), e.g. **ku-caccaliza** (*to do prematurely*).

Pronounced somewhat like the *ch* of "church," though more palatal (the long sound does not occur in English).

d and dd (short and long), e.g. **kide** (*bell*)
kidde (*bad weather*).

Pronounced respectively as in "to-day" and "red dye."

e and ee (short and long), e.g. **ku-seka** (*to laugh*)
ku-seeka (*to be grindable*).

Pronounced nearer French *é* than Swahili *e*.

f and ff (short and long), e.g. **bafe** (*let them die*)
baffe (*our people*).

Pronounced respectively as in "suffer" and "enough food." Note that with many speakers a slight *w*-sound is often heard after **f**—this is not written.

g and gg (short and long), e.g. **ku-yiga** (*to learn*)
ku-yigga (*to hunt*).

Pronounced respectively as in "bigger" and "big game." Before **i** there is a tendency towards palatalization: **magi** (*eggs*) sometimes sounding rather like "maji." This is not shown in the spelling.

i and ii (short and long), e.g. **ku-nyiga** (*to press*)
ku-nyiiga (*to be annoyed*).

Pronounced as in "see"; never pronounced as in "sit," even when short.

¹ Note that in English a double consonant often represents a *single* sound, e.g. "haddock," compare "mad dog," above.

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j and jj (short and long), e.g. **ku-jula** (*to yearn*)

ku-jjula (*to dish up food*).

Pronounced somewhat like English *j*, though more palatal. (The long sound does not occur in English.)

k and kk (short and long), e.g. **ku-kalira** (*to dry up*)

ku-kkalira (*to be settled*).

Pronounced respectively as in "sicker" and "sick cat." Before *i* there is a tendency towards palatalization: **kintu** (*thing*) sometimes sounding rather like "cintu." This is not shown in the spelling.

l (never doubled), e.g. **ku-lagira** (*to command*)

liiso (*eye*).

m and mm (short and long), e.g. **ku-kuma** (*to heap up*)

ku-mma (*to grudge*).

Pronounced respectively as in "hammer" and "immodest."

n and nn (short and long), e.g. **kiniga** (*anger*)

ku-kinnimba (*to walk proudly*).

Pronounced respectively as in "money" and "unnoticed."

ny and nny (short and long), e.g. **ku-manya** (*to know*)

ku-zannya (*to play*).

Pronounced like French *gn*. (The long sound does not occur in French.)

ŋ and ŋŋ (short and long), e.g. **ku-ŋoŋa** (*to low, like cow*)

ku-waŋŋana (*to give each other*).

Pronounced as in English "singer." (The long sound does not occur in English.)

o and oo (short and long), e.g. **ku-koza** (*to dip in relish*)

ku-kooza (*to tear off*).

Pronounced nearer French "eau" than Swahili *o*.

p and pp (short and long), e.g. **ku-papala** (*to flutter*)

ku-coppa (*to be destitute*).

Pronounced respectively as in "keeper" and "keep pace".

r (never doubled), e.g. **kiragiŋo** (*a command*)

eriiso (*eye*).

Pronounced soft as in Southern English. This sound belongs to the *l*-phoneme, and only occurs after *e*- and *i*-.

s and ss (short and long), e.g. **ku-sa** (*to grind*)

ku-ssa (*breathe*).

Pronounced respectively as in "kissing" and "this song."

t and tt (short and long), e.g. **ku-keta** (*to cut off*)

ku-ketta (*to spy*).

Pronounced respectively as in "hatter" and "that time."

u and uu (short and long), e.g. **ku-kula** (*to grow*)

ku-kuula (*to pull out grass*).

Pronounced as in "too." Never pronounced as in "foot," even when short.

v and vv (short and long), e.g. **ku-vumba** (*to arrest*)

ku-vvoola (*to blaspheme*).

Pronounced respectively as in "loving" and "love violence."

w (never doubled), e.g. **ku-wuuwa** (*to cover bananas with leaves before cooking*).

y (never doubled), e.g. **ku-yiia** (*to invent*).

z and zz (short and long), e.g. **mukazi** (*woman*)

mubazzi (*carpenter*).

Pronounced respectively as in "busy" and "his zeal."

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Note that double consonants may also stand at the beginning of words. Here they are hard for the listener to detect unless preceded by other words, when a distinct pause is noticeable, of syllabic length:

ddala (<i>indeed</i>)	nnyo (<i>very</i>)
jjajja (<i>grandfather</i>)	
ffe (<i>we, us</i>)	mmwe (<i>you, plur.</i>), ggwe (<i>you, sing.</i>)
ssebo (<i>sir</i>)	nnyabo (<i>madam</i>)
ssaalongo and nnaalongo (<i>parents of twins</i>)	
ŋŋaali (<i>crested crane</i>)	
nnyini and nnannyini (<i>owner</i>).	

Double vowels are impossible before double consonants :

babba (*they steal or they stole*—not **baabba**).

The following consonant combinations are also found:

i. *Nasal compounds*: **mp, mb, nt, nd, nc, nj, nk, ng, nf, nv, ns, nz.**

When initial the nasal sounds have syllabic value (and tone):

m-pisi (<i>hyena</i>)	m-bwa (<i>dog</i>)	n-te (<i>cow</i>)
n-diga (<i>sheep</i>)	n-cukwe (<i>terror</i>)	n-ju (<i>house</i>)
n-kuba (<i>rain</i>)	n-go (<i>leopard</i>)	n-fudu (<i>tortoise</i>)
n-vunza (<i>jigger</i>)	n-swa (<i>flying ant</i>)	n-zige (<i>locust</i>).

After a vowel the nasal sounds have no syllabic value, but the vowel is always pronounced *long* (though not written double here):

e-mpisi, e-mbwa, e-nte, etc. etc., **bandaba** (*they see me or they saw me*—not **baandaba**).

Also:

ku-kumpanya (<i>to defraud</i>)	ku-kumba (<i>to show off</i>)
ku-tanda (<i>to stride</i>)	ku-tanta (<i>to scatter</i>)
ku-kankana (<i>to shiver</i>)	ku-langa (<i>to plait</i>)
munnanfuusi (<i>hypocrite</i>)	kifunvu (<i>mound</i>)
ku-myansa (<i>to flash</i>)	ku-vunza (<i>to cause to rot</i>).

In the last four cases (*i.e.* before *f, v, s, z*), the vowel is usually nasalised and the *-n-* tends to disappear altogether with some speakers. (Compare French *danser, envie*, etc.)

ii. *Semi-vowel compounds*: **pw, bw, tw, dw, cw, jw, kw, gw, sw, zw, mw, nw, nyw, ŋw, lw, rw. py, by, ty, dy, ky, gy, my, nŷ¹, ly, ry.**

ku-pwankula (<i>eat like dog</i>)	
ku-bwama (<i>ambush</i>)	ku-byala (<i>plant slips of potatoes</i>)
ku-twala (<i>take</i>)	ku-tyaba (<i>collect firewood</i>)
ku-dwaka (<i>deceive</i>)	ku-dyaka (<i>jest</i>)
kw-ecwacwana (<i>be in rage</i>)	
kw-ejwajwana (<i>be in rage</i>)	
ku-kwata (<i>seize</i>)	ku-kyala (<i>pay a visit</i>) ²
ku-gwana (<i>be worthy</i>)	ku-gyamu (<i>fit in</i>) ²
ku-swala (<i>be ashamed</i>)	
ku-mwera (<i>shave for</i>)	ku-myansa (<i>flash</i>)
ku-nwenweka (<i>back-bite</i>)	munŷanya (<i>type of Indian</i>)
ku-nywesa (<i>cause to drink</i>)	
ku-lwala (<i>be ill</i>)	lyato (<i>boat</i>)
kw-erwaza (<i>feign illness</i>)	eryato (<i>boat</i>).

¹ **ŷ** is used to distinguish **nŷ** (that is: **n + y**) from **ny**, the palatal nasal, which is a single sound.

² **Ky** and **gy** are often hard to distinguish from **c** and **j**. Compare **ekyuma** (*iron*) and **ecuuma** (*it stinks*), **ku-ggya** (*be cooked*) and **ku-jja** (*to come*).

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Note that the vowels occurring after semi-vowel compounds are pronounced *long* in the body of the word (as in the examples above) but *short* before double consonants (as in **-lwadde**, *ill*, and **Kyaddondo**, *county name*). One notable exception is after the combination **ggw-** and **ggy-**, where the vowel may be either short or long in the body of the word. In this Dictionary the mark ~ will be used over the short vowel for the convenience of readers. The long vowel is doubled in these cases. Cf. the following:

ggwănika (<i>store</i>)	ggwaatiro (<i>peeling place</i>)
ggwōlezo (<i>tribunal</i>)	ggwoolezo (<i>customs house</i>)
ggwiso (<i>large needle</i>)	ggwiiso (<i>good luck</i>)
ku-ggyămu (<i>to come out</i>).	

Vowels at the end of words are normally short, as in **ku-va** (*to come from*), **ku-gwa** (*to fall*), **ku-tya** (*to fear*). In the genitive particle, however, and in certain words before **ki?** (*what?*), **wa?** (*where?*) and the personal possessives, they are pronounced (but not written) long. **omutwe gwā Mukasa** (*Mukasa's head*), **olabyē ki?** (*What have you seen?*), **ovā wa?** (*Where do you come from?*), **ekisō kyange** (*my knife*).

Finally, it is important, in reading the examples in the text, to remember that the final vowel of a word is always assimilated by the initial vowel of the following word, which is then pronounced long.

Thus: **agula ebintu ebirungi** (*he buys nice things*) must be read: **agul'ēbintw'ēbirungi**.

Similarly: **ndabye omuti omuwanvu** (*I have seen a tall tree*) must be read: **ndaby'ōmuty'ōmuwanvu**.

This assimilation is recognised in the Standard Orthography only in the case of particles like **ne**, **nga**, **ka**, etc., and the genitive particle. Thus: **azze n'ebintu by'omwami** (*he has come with the master's things*).

TONE MARKING

Since Luganda is a tone language, and since intonation plays a very important part in the meaning of words, tone marks have been added as diacritics above the letters, *e.g.*

à, **â** (or before letters in the case of consonants like **`p**, **`b**).

Readers who are not concerned with intonation may safely ignore these diacritics, which are not part of the Standard Orthography, but for the rest their values are as given below.

Level tones. A "grave" accent, *e.g.* **à** or **`b**, indicates relatively low voice, and an unmarked syllable following it is on a note about a major tone higher. Thus the following words are pronounced with the tone pattern (— —), *i.e.* ray me, in tonic solfa.

kùsa (*to grind*), **màta** (*milk*), **`nte** (*cow*),<sup>1</sup> **`bbwa** (*sore*).¹

Longer words:

òkusa (— — —) *to grind* (Initial Vowel form of verb).

kùtakulatakula (— — — — — — —) } (*to scratch a lot*).
òkutakulatakula (— — — — — — —) }

The same rule holds in long syllables. Thus the following words are pronounced with the tone pattern (— —), *i.e.* ray' me.

kààlo (*small village*) **kyàlo** (*village*)
mùntu (*person*) **ènte** (*cow*).

Longer words:

àkaalo (*small village*) **kùgenda** (*to go*) **kùsaana** (*to suit*) (— — —)
`ndowooza (*I think*) **òkugenda** **òkusaana** (— — — —)

¹ The first consonant here has syllabic quality.

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A vowel plus a syllabic consonant may also form a long level tone, the second half of which is a pause:

mùggazi or (more correctly) **mù'ggazi** (*doorkeeper*) (— — —)

òmuggazi (— — — —)

When a low tone syllable occurs *after* a high tone syllable, it drops lower still —about a major fourth. Thus:

kùlabà (*to see*) (— — —) ray me te

òkùlabà (— — — —) ray ray me te

mwamì (*chief*) (— — —) me· te

òmwamì (— — — —) ray me· te.

muttò (*pillow*) (— — —)

òmuttò (— — — —)

Every subsequent high tone is now one major tone higher than the *new low tone*, and therefore considerably lower than the first high tone. Thus:

kùsirika (*to be quiet*) (— — — —) ray me te doh

òkùsirika (— — — —) ray ray me te doh

òkùsirikasirika (— — — — —) ray ray me te doh doh doh doh.

With long vowels and consonants:

mwawùle (*clergyman*) **baawùle** (*clergymen*)

kw-anjùla (*spread out*) (— — —) me· te doh

òmwawùle **àbaawùle**

òkw-anjùla (— — — —) ray me· te doh

kubbika (*to cover*) (— — — —)

òkubbika (— — — —)

kùsikòndoka (*to hiccough*) (— — — —) ray me te· doh doh

òkùsikòndoka (— — — —) ray ray me te· doh doh

lùkukùùzi (*dust*) (— — — —) ray me te· doh

òlùkukùùzi (— — — —) ray ray me te· doh

kùlalà'gga (*wander about*) (— — — —)

òkùlalà'gga (— — — —)

òkùlalà'ggalalagga (— — — — —) ray ray me te· doh doh doh· doh.

This phenomenon is part of the “down drift” in tone to which this language, like most others, is subjected; that is, as the sentence proceeds, the voice (high tones and all) gradually sinks. So every time a low tone syllable occurs, the next high tone syllable is never so high as those preceding.

Example:

Tètulina kintu kyè tùlàba mù kisenge (*We can't see anything in the room*) could be rendered graphically:

“*Falling tone*”: A circumflex accent, e.g. â, indicates a falling tone of just over a major third; actually it is equivalent to a high tone plus a low tone.

E.g. **tâ** (*leave go!*) (\) me-te.

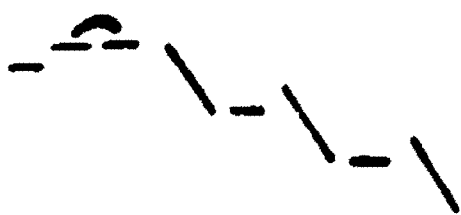
kùtâ (— \) ray me-te
òkùtâ (— — \) ray ray me-te } (*to let go*)

kìbebenû (— — — \) ray me me me-te
èkìbebenû (— — — — \) ray ray me me me-te } (*cartilage*)

“Down drift” occurs here as elsewhere.

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Tètuzzê kùlyâ bùlô (*We have not come to eat millet*) could be rendered graphically:



In long syllables the distance of the fall is the same. In fact, from the point of view of tone study, any long syllable behaves like two short syllables.

kùtûnga (- \ -) ray me-te doh (*to sew*)

òkùtûnga (- - \ -) ray ray me-te doh

mùkyâla (- \ -) ray me-te doh (*lady*)

òmùkyâla (- - \ -) ray ray me-te doh (*lady*)

When double vowels or double consonants are used, there is no need for the circumflex mark, as the low tone mark can be used on the letter concerned:

òkùtuùka (- - \ -) ray ray me-te doh (*to arrive*)

èkijiko (- - \ -) ray ray me-te doh (*spoon*)

òkùto`nnya (- - - -) ray ray me te doh (*to fall—of rain*)

òmùsa`jja (- - - -) ray ray me te doh (*man*).

Note what can be regarded as “psychological low tone” on voiceless consonants, as in

òkùco`ppa (- - - () -) ray ray me (te) doh (*to be destitute*)

òmu`kka (- - () -) ray me (te) doh (*smoke*).

The fact that the final syllable has a lowered high tone shows that the syllabic consonant belongs to the low tone category though no voice is heard. Compare words like

òmuttò (- - () -) ray me (me) te (*pillow*)

where the final syllable has actual low tone, and the first -t- “psychological high tone”.

In reading examples in the text, it should be noted that tones may be assimilated as well as vowels. Thus: **òmuntu òno** (*this person*) must be read: **òmuntw'ôno** (high tone + low tone = falling tone and long vowel).

Important typographical note

In the MS as submitted, the “grave” accent was placed *above* all letters concerned, including consonants. In order to keep down printing costs, however, it is here placed *above* vowels but *before* consonants. It is important therefore that readers of the Dictionary should not mistake a single word like **mù`ggazi** for two separate words; compare **wà mmizi**. Compare also **òkùto`nnya** (one word) and **`nnyo `nnyini** (two words).

A LUGANDA-ENGLISH AND ENGLISH-LUGANDA DICTIONARY

BEING A REVISION BY

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